



Magma Nasdaq Podium

narrating the story of how my first business was shut down by the school's management," he quips.

VLSI on the beach

After his failed business venture, young Rajeev returned to his studies and got into the best local college for his higher secondary education (pre-degree). Once settled, he resumed his carefree ways, resulting in slipping grades. It was only when one of his friends publicly shamed him that he would not qualify for engineering that Rajeev took it as a challenge to turn things around, working hard to gain admission in the National Institute of Technology, Suratkal, a beautiful engineering college with a beachside campus.

"I spent more time on the beach than in any classroom throughout the first three years of engineering," he grins, revealing his trick for avoiding lectures. "My usual trick was to make so much noise in class or the lab that I would get thrown out, receive attendance, and then be left alone to study for the final exams."

Rajeev's antics would have continued had he not crossed paths with Dr P.S. Bhatt, who taught digital design at NIT Suratkal. He recognised

Rajeev's tricks and, instead of throwing him out, told him to go to the library and study. "He followed me to the library, which was a shock to me. After two or three days of this, I started studying the course. No wonder I ended up in digital design and VLSI!" he exclaims.

Rajeev attributes Dr Bhatt for guiding him at the right time and urging him to apply for a Master's in North America. A PhD from the State University of New York (SUNY), Dr Bhatt suggested that Rajeev rewrite his last three semester exams along with the ongoing one all in one go to have a chance at scoring better. "I was the only person in the university who did that, and everyone thought I was crazy," he laughs.

"If Dr Bhatt had not shown up in my life, I would probably be doing something else. I managed to catch up in the last two semesters, and Dr Bhatt wrote the most glowing reference letters I could have ever received, which opened the doors of several schools in the US and Canada, including the University of Michigan, McGill, and Queen's

University," he narrates.

Rajeev eventually ended up going to Queen's University, Ontario—not because it was his college of preference. Young and boisterous, Rajeev had developed unbridled passions for a junior in his college, Geetha. "She was a Canadian citizen and came to Suratkal as a foreign student. My father figured out my intention behind studying in Canada, and soon after we got engaged," he smiles, recalling his vivacious youth.

The couple has two daughters—Meera and Maya. The older one, Meera, lives in London, pursuing her second Master's in AI and Biomedical Sciences, while Maya lives with the family and works at Meta. "I went to meet Geetha with the unsuccessful intention to rag her, and since then, she has been ragging me! I live in a women's hostel," he jests and goes on to narrate his first meeting with Geetha.

"I called her out of her class—being a year senior—and took her for coffee in the college canteen. I could not rag her as her uncle was my father's friend, but the warden of the men's hostel suspended me because word had spread that I did rag her. I sent word to her through two of my friends who lived in the girl's hostel to clarify that I did not rag her. She went to the principal, explained everything, and they lifted my suspension," he narrates.

"She bailed me out once, and to this day, while I claim that I went to rag her once, she has ragged me forever. However, she claims she has been bailing me out ever since!" he jokes.

Fool's day prankster to author

Rajeev cruised through Canada's cold climate and, after graduation, was faced with two choices—a job at Bell Northern Research (BNR), a research subsidiary of Nortel,



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